

A Critical Review of Canadian Language Education Policy

Canada is well-known as a bilingual state. The *Official Languages Act* (OLA, 1985), which establishes English and French as the two equal official languages of Canada (s. 2), is widely supported by Canadians of many different social strata. A survey conducted in 2016 shows that more than three quarters of Canadians approve of the OLA across all provinces and age groups with younger Canadians, Francophones, and Quebecois being the most in favor (Office of the Commissioner of Official Languages, 2021). Survey respondents most often cite recognition of Canada's history and culture as the reason for their support of the Act. The unfortunate reality is, however, that this bilingual view greatly simplifies Canada's rich multilingual nature and especially the place of Indigenous languages in Canadian society.

This bilingual policy is actualized in several ways. Most recently, the Canadian government has set forth an action plan, the *Action Plan for Official Languages 2023–2028* (Action Plan), that outlines the expenditure of an unprecedented 4.1 billion Canadian dollars for the development of bilingualism in Canada, including several educational initiatives (Canadian Heritage, 2023, p. 8). Education of Indigenous languages, on the other hand, is mostly governed by the Minister of Indigenous Services as laid out in the *Indian Act* (1985, ss. 2(1), 114(2)). The Canadian legislature also passed the *Indigenous Languages Act* (ILA, 2019) in an effort to recognize Indigenous language rights (s. 5). The Act establishes the Office of the Commissioner of Indigenous Languages which assists in the teaching of Indigenous languages among other efforts to support their development (s. 12(1), 23(1)).

While Canada's policies are well-meaning and claim to promote diversity and multilingualism as well as support Indigenous language rights, the reality is that they are still quite problematic. This essay critically analyzes Canadian language education policy through the lens of recent scholarship on multilingual education. After reviewing Canadian language ecology and different theories of multilingual education, policies are then analyzed one by one in light of this context. Finally, some informed recommendations are made to increase the status of minority and Indigenous languages and their inclusion in Canadian education.

Background

Linguistic Ecology

Indigenous Languages and Colonization. There are approximately 90 Indigenous languages spoken in Canada (McIvor & Ball, 2019, p. 14). These languages were actually the first to be spoken in what are now Canadian lands. Today, the peoples that speak these languages are known as First Nations, Inuit, and Metis. The leaders of these Indigenous communities assert that all of these 90 languages are at risk of extinction (p. 23). Government

statistics show that only 17.2% of Indigenous peoples can hold a conversation in an Indigenous language (Dicks & Genesee, 2017, p. 5). Since adult speakers are few, transmission levels to the next generation are low (McIvor & Ball, 2019, p. 23). Furthermore, since English or French are often used as the home language, school is often the only environment where young students might be exposed to their Indigenous language. In these circumstances, the Indigenous language is viewed as a second language to learn.

Canada has played a significant role in the decline of these Indigenous languages. There is a long history of discriminatory policies, forced relocations, and assimilation efforts (*Indigenous Languages Act*, 2019, Preamble). For example, Indigenous children were previously forced into schools where they were not allowed to speak their Indigenous language (McIvor & Ball, 2019, p. 15). This measure alone led many Indigenous languages to near extinction. Even as this practice ended, Indigenous schools were still required to teach the provincially-approved curriculum. The government recognizes their fault in the preamble to the ILA (2019), which was itself an attempt to reconcile with Indigenous peoples. Whether Canada's attempts at reparation have been effective will be analyzed in the following sections.

Immigration and Heritage Languages. Over 200 languages are spoken every day in Canada (Canadian Heritage, 2023, p. 24). Several waves of immigration from all over the world have made Canada an extremely diverse country. As of 2021, roughly one in four Canadians was born outside of Canada (p. 12). Despite English-French bilingualism being the official policy, there are many Canadians who do not speak either official language as their mother tongue or home language (Duff, 2008, p. 75). These people are known as *Allophones*. Surprisingly, in urban areas like Vancouver and Toronto, Allophones make up about 40% of the population (p. 88). In Montreal, a French-speaking city, that figure is 20%. In Quebec, there are more Allophones than Anglophones. While German, Italian, and Ukrainian were previously the most common Allophone languages, languages like Chinese and Punjabi have seen an influx (p. 75).

Beginning around 1971, the government began to support the idea of a multicultural Canada instead of an assimilated one (Duff, 2008, p. 72). This policy is often referred to as the Canadian mosaic, as opposed to the American melting pot. As part of this push for multiculturalism, Canada began to support the development of what was termed as *heritage languages*. Heritage languages generally refer to all languages spoken by Canadians other than English or French. They may or may not include Indigenous languages. These languages are taught in school either outside of the regular school day or as part of a bilingual program

(p. 73). Most recently, the term *heritage language* has given way to *international languages*, which highlights a more economic motivation for maintaining their development (p. 82).

English and French. While Canada is officially a bilingual country, statistics of individual English-French bilingualism are quite low with only around 18% of Canadians reporting speaking both English and French (Canadian Heritage, 2023, p. 12). Despite being a significant partner in the establishment of Canada, French people were historically in a disadvantaged position (Genesee & Lindholm-Leary, 2008, p. 3). Previous policies occasionally prohibited the use of French and favored English, even in French-speaking Quebec. Social and political movements in the 1960s known as the “Quiet Revolution” advocated for making French equal in footing with English, leading to the passing of the OLA (p. 4). However, English remains in more prominent use, and French speakers have been steadily declining (Canadian Heritage, 2023, p. 12).

Theoretical Framework

Monolingual Bias and Translanguaging. Formal education systems all around the world often exhibit a monolingual bias (Lüpke & Cissé, 2023, p. 43). *Monolingual bias* is the idea that languages are named and bounded entities that ought not mix (Phyak et al., 2023, p. 231). An extension of this idea is the creation of linguistic norms which disown language users of their own language (Lüpke & Cissé, 2023, p. 48). They are dependent on some external authority for their language use to be accepted. Monolingual bias manifests itself in school where languages coexist but in parallel, never together. Students are graded according to their ability to stick to the monolingual, native-speaker norm, and language mixing is viewed as deficient language use (p. 51).

The practice of translanguaging challenges the monolingual bias. *Translanguaging* is “the deployment of a speaker’s full linguistic repertoire without regard for watchful adherence to the socially and politically defined boundaries of named...languages” (Otheguy et al., 2025, as cited in Phyak et al., 2023, p. 231). Unlike traditional education, translanguaging reflects the true, lived reality of multilingual speakers who use all of their repertoire in daily interactions (Reilly et al., 2022, p. 13). Translanguaging in the classroom has also been shown to deepen the students’ understanding of subject-matter content (Dicks & Genesee, 2017, p. 7). Taken to an extreme, the concept of *ubuntu translanguaging* from South Africa suggests that “no languaging act is complete with only linguistic features [which] belong to one language” (Phyak et al., 2023, p. 232).

Colonialism and Education. Global formal education systems did not develop a monolingual bias in a vacuum. It developed often as a result of colonial history. Colonizers

and missionaries introduced the idea of named languages and mother tongues into Africa when they arrived (Makoni, 2012, p. 91). It follows then that the languages which benefit from this monolingual bias are mostly those of colonial inheritance (Lüpke & Cissé, 2023, p. 45). The term *coloniality of schooling* refers to school systems which are continuously based on the language and epistemologies of the colonizers (Phyak et al., 2023, p. 224). These types of systems maintain a power structure where the colonizers are advantaged. Coloniality of schooling is also present in modern multilingual education programs which claim to meet the needs of minority languages but fail to meaningfully change the power structures.

Mohanty (2019) proposed a three-layer hierarchical model which describes the linguistic power structure in India but could also be used in other global contexts (pp. 329–330). At the top of the pyramid is English, a globally dominant and colonial language. In the middle layer are other official languages of India or its regions. At the bottom of the pyramid lies the Indigenous, tribal, and minority languages. In the educational system, students with backgrounds from the bottom of the pyramid are disadvantaged by having to cross the “double divide” and navigate their education in two additional privileged languages. Resources are inevitably focused closer to the top of the pyramid.

Policy Change. Kosonen and Benson (2021) developed a framework for describing how policy change is done effectively in education systems (p. 25–26). There are three types of actors: actors from above, actors from the side, and actors from below (p. 34–35). Influence from above comes from countries or autonomous regions with power. Some of the language planning measures available to them include official language designations, national educational policy, and other legislation. Influence from the side comes from secondary institutions with relevant expertise. These include United Nations (UN) agencies, non-governmental organizations (NGOs), donors, and academics. Some of the language planning measures available to them are pilot programs, material creation, orthographical development, and advocacy. Finally, influence from below comes from local groups and individuals with vested interest. These include religious groups, cultural associations, and in the sphere of education, parent-teacher organizations (PTOs). Some of the language planning measures available to them are grassroots literacy campaigns and other local initiatives.

Action at any one of these levels has the potential to influence action on another level (Kosonen and Benson, 2021, p. 36). There are four trajectories: from above to the side and below (top-down), from the bottom to the side and above (bottom-up), from the side with below to above, and from the side to above then to below. Kosonen and Benson identified a couple keys to successful policy change using this model (p. 48–49). First, the minority

language communities must be included in the process to ensure the result meets their needs. Second, sustainable change requires action from all three directions either simultaneously or sequentially. It could take decades for this kind of collaboration to take place.

Policy Review

The Official Language Act and Action Plan

Policy. Pillar 1 of the Action Plan deals with increasing the Francophone population in Canada (Canadian Heritage, 2023, p. 17–18). With regard to education, the last measure invests 10.5 million Canadian dollars in English- and French-language training for French-speaking and allophone immigrants.

Pillar 2 of the Action Plan aims to promote educational opportunities in both official languages across the whole lifespan (Canadian Heritage, 2023, p. 20–22). The document uses the term *minority language* to refer to the official language that is less spoken in a given area. The goal of the policy is to provide comprehensive education to every Canadian in their “first official language” with opportunities to learn their “second official language.” The motivation behind the policy is reportedly to address labor shortages, improve access to information, and boost the economy. Examples of policy implementations include funding for so-called “minority-language education” and “post-secondary education in the minority language.” There is a special effort to support the French language. For example, there is funding for French-as-a-second-language education, including French immersion programs to increase the number of English-French bilinguals. Two other programs support French-language scientific research and healthcare access.

Language immersion programs in Canada have historically involved strict isolation of the two official languages (Dicks & Genesee, 2017, p. 7). Students are only to speak French during periods of French-language instruction and English during periods of English-language instruction. Such a French-only policy was supposedly developed out of fear that English will naturally dominate and prevent French learning.

Analysis. The OLA and Action Plan both operate under the assumption of monolingual bias in that they treat languages as named and bounded entities that ought not to mix. This is made obvious, for example, with the strict separation of English and French in Canadian language immersion programs. The idea that language mixing will prevent French learning is erroneous. When learners can use their whole repertoire and practice translanguaging in the classroom, communicative ability has been shown to improve (Dicks & Genesee, 2017, p. 7).

While French has been in a disadvantaged position compared to English, the OLA and the Action Plan's efforts to improve the status of French only strengthens the status quo that the colonial languages are on top of the hierarchy, like in Mohanty's (2019) model. At the same time, the policies ignore their impact on national minority language communities. The Action Plan views official languages as tools to produce economic outcomes and fails to recognize the value and identities of so-called allophone immigrants. Given the huge Allophone population, it is not in line with reality to assert that the two official languages really represent all Canadians. The term *allophone* itself (lit. 'different-speaking') is a form of othering and places speakers of languages other than English and French lower in the hierarchy.

The Action Plan is a top-down policy which attempts to create aggressive demographic change only from above. As Kosonen and Benson's (2021) framework reveals, policy change from one direction is unsustainable (pp. 48–49). The policies only reflect the will of the federal government and are not based on the will of the language communities themselves. Failure to include the community and other actors from below in the policy-creation process reduces the probability of real change. Just because the government prescribes this desire for a strong French-speaking community does not make it the will of the people.

The Indian Act

Policy. The *Indian Act* grants the Minister of Indigenous Services sweeping control over the education of Indigenous children (1985, ss. 114–117). Section 114 of the Act enables the Minister to enter agreements with provincial and territorial governments and local school boards regarding the education of "Indian children." These bodies are those who are normally responsible for education in their respective regions. The Minister is also granted power to "establish, operate and maintain schools for Indian children." Section 115 grants the Minister complete control to regulate teaching, education, and discipline in said schools. Section 116 compels "every Indian child who has attained the age of seven years" to attend these schools operated by the Minister.

Analysis. The *Indian Act* (1985) effectively perpetuates the coloniality of schooling in Canada by forcing Indigenous children to attend schools that do not reflect their own languages and epistemologies and which they cannot influence. The current system appears to provide a service to Indigenous children by ensuring a basic education for all, but the structure of the education system fails to empower the Indigenous population as equals. Indigenous students are still required to learn the colonial languages and receive

subject-matter education in the colonial languages. The “double divide” noted by Mohanty’s (2019) model of India is apparent here too, as Indigenous languages sit beneath French in the middle of the hierarchy and English at the top (pp. 329–330). The content itself does not reflect their cultural and linguistic background either.

As with the OLA and Action Plan, the *Indian Act* (1985) is a top-down attempt to affect change. While the Minister can make agreements with side actors like local school boards (s. 114), the Minister is the only one empowered to influence language education among Indigenous communities (s. 115). The side actors have less authority to initiate change, but they are involved in carrying out directives from above which usually reinforce the supremacy of the official languages. Again, the colonial power remains at the top of the hierarchy.

The Indigenous Languages Act

Policy. The stated purpose of the *Indigenous Languages Act* (ILA, 2019) is to “support and promote the use of Indigenous languages, including Indigenous sign languages” and to “support the efforts of Indigenous peoples to reclaim, revitalize, maintain and strengthen Indigenous languages” (ss. 5(a–b)). The government also promises to fund these efforts and collaborate with the Indigenous governments and organizations (s. 5(d)). The Act is an endorsement of the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (s. 5(g)), which states that “Indigenous peoples have the right to establish and control their educational systems and institutions providing education in their own language, in a manner appropriate to their cultural methods of teaching and learning” (United Nations, 2007, p. 13). These responsibilities are carried out by the Minister of Canadian Heritage and the Office of the Commissioner of Indigenous Languages (*Indigenous Languages Act*, 2019, ss. 2, 7, 12(1)).

The ILA (2019, s. 25) pledges to support efforts such as research and documentation of Indigenous languages, community assessments, and the development of culturally-appropriate education programs. Section 10.1 of the ILA states that access to federal government services in Indigenous languages is only necessary to provide if the institution has the capacity and there is sufficient demand.

Analysis. The ILA lays out a policy that is ambitious and mostly affirmative of Indigenous languages and cultures, but once again, the letter of a policy may not match the reality of its implementation. The choice to follow through on these directives is still entirely up to the Minister and Commissioner of Indigenous Languages, and the policy gives them freedom to act in ways that are not always in the best interest of Indigenous communities.

The prime example of this freedom is Section 10.1 which does not make Indigenous language access compulsory. Terms like “sufficient demand” and stipulations on the administration’s capacity are vague enough that the Minister could be justified never providing access at all. This policy is also in direct contrast with the official languages which are granted equal status and privilege. Again, the Act is a gesture of goodwill without meaningfully changing the power structure.

Clauses encouraging consultation with Indigenous governing bodies and organizations are a positive development. However, it remains unclear if this consultation practice grants the Indigenous bodies meaningful autonomy or if the current top-down policy trajectory will remain functionally in place. As the UN Declaration states, “Indigenous peoples have the right to establish and control their educational systems,” not just be consulted about them (United Nations, 2007, p. 13). As long as the *Indian Act* (1985) remains in effect, the educational system will continue to be under the control of the Minister of Indigenous Services (ss. 114–117).

Conclusion

Summary

Canadian language education policies speak of a desire to promote Canada’s rich linguistic diversity and honor Indigenous language communities but effectively act as if the communities themselves need saving with the help of the colonial power. English and French remain privileged languages on the top of the hierarchy, and billions of dollars are spent on their development and education in the name of economic development. So-called Allophones are expected to assimilate by learning one of the official languages, and their languages go neglected. Indigenous languages in particular were historically banned from the school setting and are still not integrated into the curriculum. Indigenous governments are left out of decision making even when it involves their own social and cultural institutions.

Recommendations

To better respect and promote Canada’s linguistic diversity, here are a few suggestions of changes that could be made. Firstly, the monolingual bias should be reexamined in the school setting. Even in immersion programs, which are quite popular in Canada, limiting the use of students’ full repertoires such as through French-only environments is detrimental to their development. Translanguaging should be encouraged in the classroom as far as it aids communication. Secondly, Sections 114 through 117 of the *Indian Act* (1985) should be repealed. These are the sections which reinforce the coloniality of schooling in Canada. Indigenous groups should be in charge of their own education, not the federal Minister.

Lastly, the *Indigenous Languages Act* (2019) should be amended to fund actors from the side and from below to make their own decisions. Governmental action is aggressively top-down, and action from all directions is necessary for sustainable change.

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